

The IIM Grad Who Bet His Second Act on Cake

Suresh Naik built a career in telecom and business education before a pandemic hobby, baking for family and friends, turned into a dessert chain chasing a Guinness World Record and a very specific ambition: making foreigners queue for an Indian bakery brand.

Most founders build one identifiable skill and stay inside it. Suresh Naik's path to Harley's Fine Baking ran through an IIM Calcutta finance degree, a leadership stint at Tech Mahindra, a telecom engineering venture, and the founding of one of Telangana's leading business schools, none of which had anything to do with pastry.

What changed course began during the first wave of the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020. With the world at a standstill, Naik found himself spending more time baking, gradually turning a personal interest into a serious hobby. What began as experimentation in the kitchen grew into a fascination with the craft, eventually leading him to start a small boutique baking brand as the first wave receded.

But it was during the devastating second wave of the pandemic that the idea behind Harley's acquired a very different meaning. Spending time with bakers, kitchen workers and others who made their living in the sector, Naik saw first-hand the vulnerabilities faced by the largely marginalised working class behind India's baking and dessert industry. These were people with remarkable skills and craftsmanship, yet their work often came with little recognition, social standing or professional pride.

That experience reshaped his ambition. Instead of simply building another successful bakery, Naik decided to create a world-class Indian dessert brand built around the very people whose skills had traditionally remained behind the scenes — an

Suresh Naik
Founder & CEO
HARLEY'S

organisation that could give them opportunity, recognition, dignity and pride in their craft. The business opportunity remained compelling, but the purpose became larger: to prove that a globally admired premium dessert brand could be built in India while elevating the people who actually make it possible.

Harley's launched in 2021 as a boutique café built around the Russian Medovik cake, and the timeline since has been unusually steep. The brand has expanded to more than 70 stores across six Indian cities in five years, and in December 2024 it set a Guinness World Record for the largest Russian Medovik honey cake ever made, a 2,254 kilogram, 70 foot creation assembled by more than 500 bakers and support staff at a single Hyderabad venue, breaking the previous Dubai held record by roughly tenfold.

"This achievement reflects the hard work, dedication, and creativity of everyone involved," Naik said at the ceremony, a line that doubled as a mission statement for how he has scaled the brand: through systems and people rather than a single celebrity chef.

That systems first instinct now runs the backend too. Harley's has built its multi city operations on a cloud restaurant platform giving management



live visibility into inventory, wastage and outlet level performance across its kitchens, infrastructure built specifically to support the international rollout now underway into Dubai and London, alongside further expansion within India to Ahmedabad, Surat and Delhi. The ambition Naik has attached to that expansion is unusually pointed: to build India's first global dessert café chain aimed at non Indian audiences, and make foreign customers queue for an Indian baked product the way Indians have long queued for foreign dessert chains.

"My vision is to make Harley's a global name synonymous with excellence and sustainability," Naik has said, a target he backs with Harley's Foundation, which marks birthdays for orphaned children and elderly people without family, on the belief that entrepreneurship itself is the most sustainable form of philanthropy when it is built to employ and mentor at scale; Naik has personally mentored more than 400 entrepreneurs through his business school work.

As Harley's carries its Medovik cake toward Western markets that have spent decades exporting dessert culture to India, Naik is testing whether the flow can run in reverse and whether an Indian brand, on quality alone, can make the rest of the world wait in line.